



PROF. (DR.) MANOJRANJAN NAYAK - A VISIONARY EDUCATIONIST

Siksha 'O' Anusandhan Deemed to be University, the highest ranked university in Odisha today, has metamorphosed into a centre of excellence from a very modest beginning in less than three decades. There was a time when Odisha was listed among states which lacked facilities for good education. Students who could afford to study outside the state migrated to big cities to pursue careers in professional courses. But it was not possible for many meritorious students.

At least one visionary, Prof. (Dr.) Manojranjan Nayak, thought the scenario could be changed.

A brilliant student himself who secured high marks in High School Certificate examination and I. Sc., Prof. (Dr.) Nayak, graduated in electrical engineering from the Regional Engineering College (presently NIT), Rourkela, completed M. Tech in Computer Science from IIT, Kharagpur and did his Ph.D in the same subject from the Odisha University of Agriculture and Technology (OUAT), Bhubaneswar.

He taught as a faculty in the College of Engineering and Technology under OUAT for a few years and was held in high esteem by the students. He became a professor while in his early thirties. Prof. (Dr.) Nayak took the first step to alter the scenario when he established an engineering college in Bhubaneswar in 1996 known as Institute of Technical Education and Research (ITER) which has blossomed to be counted as one of the finest engineering colleges in the country today.

Prof. (Dr.) Nayak subsequently set up institutes imparting education in management sciences, medical sciences, hospitality and tourism management, nursing, pharmaceutical sciences and dental sciences. It was on July 17, 2007 that the University Grants Commission (UGC) conferred on these institutes the status of a Deemed to be University under section 3 of the UGC Act, 1956. The institutes today operate as constituents of Siksha 'O' Anusandhan Deemed to be University (SOA).

Three more institutes imparting education in legal studies, agricultural sciences and veterinary sciences were set up subsequently under the SOA umbrella.

The university has been relentlessly pursuing the vision of its founder to make classy professional education accessible to students across the region while focusing on quality research. It was ranked 14th in the country by the National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF) in 2024. SOA's faculty of medical sciences was ranked 21st by NIRF while faculty of engineering was placed in the 26th place nationally. Its faculties of legal studies and dental sciences have been ranked 9th in the country in 2024.

SOA has been ranked in the 1201-1400 bracket in the QS World University Ranking 2025 and placed in 1201-1250 overall bracket in QS World University Sustainability Ranking 2025. In Times Higher Education (THE) World University Ranking 2025, SOA has been placed in the 1201-1250 bracket. A new feather was added to SOA's glowing cap in 2025 when it found place in a distinguished list of four institutions in India in the Times Higher Education (THE) World Reputation Rankings, 2025, the other three being I.I.Sc, Bengaluru, IIT-Delhi and IIT-Madras.

The National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC) re-accredited SOA with A++ in 2022. The UGC had also conferred on SOA Category-I Graded Autonomy status while National Board of Accreditation had accredited several courses run by the university.

Continuing to grow and expand, SOA has set up 20 research centres which have been working in 27 identified thrust areas. Some of the ongoing research work is supported by grants sanctioned by several external agencies including the Department of Science and Technology, Department of Biotechnology and Defence Research and Development Organisation.

Research work of the SOA faculty members and research scholars regularly get published in reputed peer reviewed national and international journals. The university has 14,476 Scopus indexed publications to its credit so far with h-Index of 124. Researchers at SOA have so far applied for 1266 patents of which 547 have been published and patents granted in 85 cases.

The Institute of Medical Sciences and SUM Hospital, SOA's faculty of medical sciences-- now reckoned as one of the principal healthcare centres in Odisha— has also been accredited by NABH and NABL.

Under Prof. (Dr.) Nayak's leadership, IMS and SUM Hospital remained in the forefront of the battle against Covid-19 pandemic when it set up five stand alone Covid Hospitals in the state with more than 2500 beds in Odisha in collaboration with the state government treating thousands of patients successfully.

SOA's healthcare initiative has been further strengthened with the establishment of two other branches of IMS and SUM Hospital at Phulnakhara, close to Bhubaneswar, and the south Odisha city of Berhampur, adding 1200 and 200 new beds respectively, while offering the latest cutting-edge treatment to patients. Prof. (Dr.) Nayak, who has guided 30 Ph. D scholars and 70 post-graduate students with their projects, also set up the 575 bedded SUM Ultimate Medicare, a stand-alone one-stop, next-generation multi-super specialty quaternary care hospital in Bhubaneswar.